



absence of an alternative. Disunited and disintegrating, the Opposition is losing the argument as well as the space. The story on the Right is all about the pathology of a self-defeating leadership. With Atal Bihari Vajpayee in autumnal retreat, the BJP does not have a leader who can inspire the cadre, unify the allies and win the argument. L.K. Advani, the so-called tallest leader of the party, refuses to accept his redundancy. He is a towering symbol of the fossilisation of an idea that once swayed the mind of India.

It would have been an altogether different story in Maharashtra and Haryana had there been a Vajpayee at the helm. The Shiv Sena family feud in Maharashtra would not have assumed politically suicidal pro-

too despite Rahul Gandhi's go-alone experiments in the heartland. The new Mrs G encourages strong regional leadership—an Ashok Chavan in Maharashtra and a Bhopinder Singh Hooda in Haryana, leaders who are winners as well as good administrators. And she has consistently succeeded in keeping the traditional anti-Congress vote divided or exploiting it to her advantage in the name of secularism. That is why she is not particularly scared of either Mayawati or Mulayam, both of whom may have no love for the Congress president but care for her definition of secularism. And in an India where dissent rhymes with shrillness, Sonia appeals to what one of her young MPs calls the constituency of sobriety.

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portions had there been an acceptable patriarch in the House of Saffron. Now the house is on fire. In Haryana too, there was no leader in the BJP who could retain Om Prakash Chautala as a partner. Anti-Congressism is not dead in spite of Sonia's ability to retain the shine—there are still such powerful heartland brands like Mayawati, Nitish Kumar and Mulayam Singh Yadav. What India doesn't have is a leader who can unite the splintering forces of anti-Congressism. Maharashtra and Haryana further emphasise the truth. The Opposition may have discredited nationalist leaders but it certainly doesn't have a national leader.

Sonia has made best use of her worst opposition. She is fast turning out to be a fine practitioner of coalition dharma, that

So, are we into the age of infallible Sonia? She keeps winning but she is not winning big. She has not repeated her Lok Sabha performance either in Maharashtra or Haryana. Apart from Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Delhi, the Congress is not in power in any of the big states. India's most successful—and powerful—politician is yet to get the absolute mandate of India. She has rebuilt the Congress as the natural ruling party of India on the wreckage of the Indian Right. Sonia Gandhi needs a foundation stronger than that to regain the Congress's original self: the great banyan tree of a party that nurtures every shade of national as well as regional aspiration. She needs more than what a disintegrating opposition can gift her. ■